



FERNS

Also known as pteridophytes, ferns include around 12,000 species and thrive in damp environments, such as forests. Fern leaves are called fronds, and they carry spores on their underside. These spores produce tiny plants that reproduce in turn, giving rise to the next generation of adult ferns.

CONIFERS

This gymnosperm group of about 550 species comprises mostly large evergreen trees. Conifers can photosynthesize even in winter, and they are often characterized by leaves shaped like needles. This group includes pines, firs, spruces, cedars, cypresses, and yews.



Pine



Horsetail

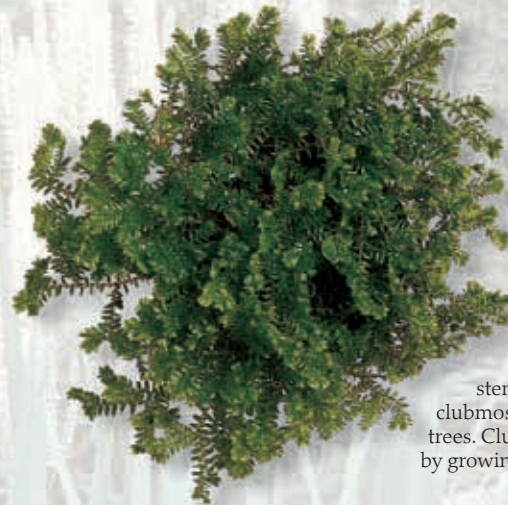
HORSETAILS

These ancient plants are also called sphenophytes. Around 300 million years ago, they reached heights of 50 ft (15 m). Today there are only about 35 species left, most of which are under 3 ft (1 m) tall. This family is closely related to the fern group.

Vast horsetail forests once grew on Earth



Cones are produced during the summer months



Clubmoss

CLUBMOSES

Clubmosses, or lycopodophytes, existed as far back as 430 million years ago. Today's clubmosses are small, with overlapping leaves and creeping stems, but some prehistoric clubmosses grew into giant trees. Clubmosses reproduce by growing spores.

CYCADS

Cycads are gymnosperms that grow in tropical regions. Despite being similar in appearance to palms, they are not related to them. Cycads were abundant in the Jurassic Period (208–146 million years ago), but there are now just 100 species left. Their attractive leaves make them popular garden plants.



Cycad

Welwitschia mirabilis, also known as the tumbao

GNETOPHYTES

Although they are gymnosperms, these cone-bearing desert plants resemble flowering plants. Gnetophytes were once thought to be a missing link between angiosperms and conifers. There are about 70 species.